

By Anthony Fenech
Detroit Free Press

One day, I'll tell you about how much of an honor this has been, to cover my favorite team growing up, at the only place I ever wanted to work, in the city that runs through my blood.

I'll tell you about how it all started, like it started for so many of us sports writers, except I was able to read him every day. He could have left, I remember him writing sometime, but he became ours, and I remember the feeling I had when reading him and those teenage dreams I had, thinking to myself, "That's going to be me one day." But not today. Sitting at the kitchen table in my first house – the house my grandparents raised a family in – not today. Because the eyes are already welling up and the front door is open and I love this place and its people and, as it finally hits me, with every word that could follow, recounting the dream that has been, I know my heart will push me closer to closing that door.

This is the last story I'm writing as a Free Press Sports Writer, maybe forever. Give me a second.

In a few days, I'm starting a new job at the Boston Globe, covering the Red Sox. This was not a difficult decision. The challenge of a baseball writing lifetime awaits and I'm excited to take it on.

If these are, indeed, the last words I write in this paper, I want to make them count by thanking the people who have made these past 12 years possible, who have become family, who I am forever indebted to for their guidance and patience and friendship.

To Matt Fiorito, who opened the door to the Free Press for me. To Gene Myers, who I owe my career to. To Laurie Delves, who is like an aunt to me.

To John Lowe, who taught me everything about baseball reporting that I know.

To Terrance Collins, who allowed me to spread my wings, and Kirkland Crawford, who wrote my first letter of reference.

To Maiya Hayes and Mari delaGarza, who are too young to be like aunts to me but too old to be sisters, so they're just good friends. To Ryan Ford, who I've spent way too many hours at the Anchor with.

To the grumpy old guard who let a young and dumb kid become one of them – Tim Marcincoski, Jim Dwight, Steve Schrader, Tom Panzenhagen, Bill Collison and I don't want to forget about Lee Snider.

To David and Shelly Darby, who were just really comforting and supportive of my ambitions. To Kevin Bull and James Jahnke, who put up with way more than they needed to.

To George Sipple, a great teammate who became a great friend; Drew Sharp, who will stand the test of time as the sports columnist Detroit needed; and Jon Morosi, who spent

To my fellow Free Press Sports Writers, who were supportive and not threatened when I was working on the desk and definitely coming for their jobs. You know the names.

You read their bylines every day.

To my boys on the prep crew – Corey Greenleaf, Jon Machota, Marty Dobek, Corey Frederick, Charlie Dwight and even Kevin Klein – those were the days. To Mark Francescutti for being crazy and Scott Bell for I don't know what, I just wanted to shout him out.

To Paul Anger, for making me prove it, and Julie Topping, for putting me in check. To Angela Lopez and Amy Huschka, two women who I adore; Robert Huschka, who gave great advice; and the past, present and often overlooked glue of the newsroom, Thelma Oakes and Dora Hernandez.

To the new guard: Chris Thomas, who took the reins of our department by working his tail off and kept the trains running on time during a period of instability; Dana Sulonen, who I love working with; and Marlowe Alter, who works the worst hours with no recognition. These people face impossible tasks day in and day out, especially when their baseball beat writer spends too much time schmoozing in the dugout all summer.

To Peter Bhatia, a personable figure who has provided secure leadership in a time of uncertainty in the newsroom.

It has been a privilege to grow up in this newsroom, from late nights in the old building, reading Michael Rosenberg stories in one of Laurie's many binders of front pages – I stole more than a few – to nights at the Anchor.

To my beat writing brethren, especially Lynn Henning, a trusted confidante with a heart of gold; Jason Beck and Chris Iott, who I am indebted to for the help they gave me in my first year; and Chris McCosky, who still amazes me with his blanket coverage.

To the many faces in the Tigers organization who were accessible over the years, most notably Al Avila, who occasionally returned my calls; Ron Colangelo, who has a job to do but made ours easier to do;

It will be tough and it will take time, but I believe one day they will get it done

because Avila has surrounded himself with guys like Mike Russell. One of the things I'm looking forward to most about my new job is being able to talk to Russ again.

To Kirk Gibson, the first manager I ever covered, who challenged me, taught me and eventually, trusted me. I have not forgotten what some have: Gibson was a great manager.

And to you, the Free Press reader and Tigers fan. You are the reason why this job is so great. I know you so well because I am you.

If we never speak again, know that

Alright, guys. It's been real. The Tigers turned down a Michael Fulmer for Alex Bregman trade in 2017. Keep in touch.

Crazy, isn't it. Back when I met you I was going for an internship there and said I would pack you into my suitcase. Now I got the most important job there and you

Well, you're still in Ohio but hey. Good luck to you

One more thing: The Tigers turned down a Michael Fulmer for Alex Bregman trade in 2017.

trade in which the key pieces were Michael Fulmer and Alex Bregman. Keep in touch.

The Tigers turned down a Michael Fulmer-for-Alex Bregman trade in 2017

To the many faces in the Tigers organization who were accessible over the years. Often times, our intentions conflict.

from the latest of nights in the old building with on

at an young age by working his tail off and kept the trains running on time

And especially to the new guard, Chris Thomas, who step

cool guys Joe Cybulski and the late Steve Anderson, who I
To the new guard: Chris

To those from the first floor of the old Free Press building – Angela Lopez, who I adore;

never seemed to feel threatened when I was working on the desk and definitely coming for their jobs. This remains one of the greatest

To the grumpy old guard,

To John Lowe, who taught me everything about baseball

To the grumpy old guard, a bunch of guys I loved sitting around on the night shift –
Tim M

To the grumpy old guard

To Matt Fiorito, the gregarious bowling writer who saw enough in me to give me the chance to answer phones on the prep crew. To Gene Myers, who

first gave me the opportunity to answer phones on the prep crew. To

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will inch closer to closing that door. Give me a minute.
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and it's finally hitting me.

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Because the eyes are already welling up and the front door is open and I love this place, its people, it is me. It's comfortable. Comfort is key.

Because the eyes are already welling up and with every word about

Because the eyes are already welling up

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and the teenage dreams I had, thinking to myself:

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